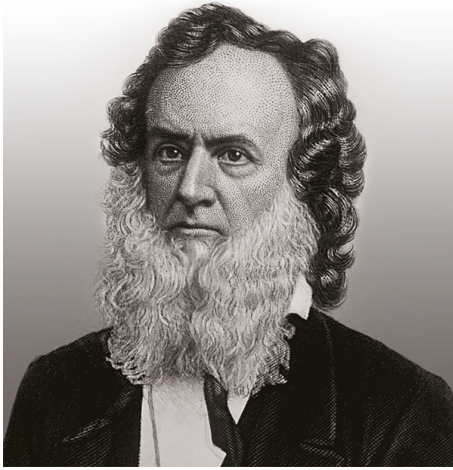


UNION POLITICIAN (1802-78)

GIDEON WELLES



An important prewar newspaper editor and politician in Connecticut, Welles worked in the Navy Department during the War with Mexico. He developed anti-slavery views and opposed the Compromise of 1850's controversial Fugitive Slave Law. He joined the Republican Party after the passage of the Kansas-Nebraska Act in 1854.

As navy secretary during the Civil War, he and his chief deputy, Gustavus Vasa Fox, proved to be energetic and effective administrators. Not only did they supervise the rapid expansion of the Union navy, but they also exercised good judgment in selecting senior officers.

Taking the ports

Joint army-navy operations to close down various Confederate ports became an important part of the war effort, and the first Federal military successes post-Bull Run involved the capture of ports in North Carolina and South Carolina. Not only did these amphibious operations close coastal entry points into the Confederacy, but they also provided bases at which Union ships could fuel and draw supplies near their assigned duty stations, instead of making the long journey to their posts from their Northern bases. The Union navy would capture Wilmington, North Carolina—the last Confederate port—in January 1865.

The effectiveness of the blockade remains uncertain. Some historians have argued that it “won” the war for the Union, while others see its effects as negligible. The answer probably lies somewhere in between.

By itself, the Union blockade could not have ensured a Federal victory, but the siege played an important role in the eventual exhaustion of Southern resources. Its increasing effectiveness prevented the Confederacy from easily importing military supplies (including those related to railroads), and the closing of coastal